



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 21

# MARYLAND

## WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

*Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Maryland's family courts and child-welfare system.*

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# 39

MARYLAND FAMILIES ON RECORD · 71  
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18 MONTHS  
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING  
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 9, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

15 OF 24

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

# MARYLAND AT A GLANCE.

Across 39 Maryland families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

|                                                                                               |                                                                                                                  |                                                                          |                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>CHILDREN IMPACTED</div> <div>71</div> <div>38 of 39 families reported child counts</div> | <div>MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN</div> <div>\$362,000</div> <div>median across 9 families reporting 3+ categories</div> | <div>MEDIAN MONTHS LOST</div> <div>18</div> <div>of parenting time</div> | <div>WENT PRO SE</div> <div>35.9%</div> <div>23.1% after running out of money</div> |
| <div>SUBMISSIONS</div> <div>39</div>                                                          | <div>AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY</div> <div>1.9</div>                                                                  | <div>FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN</div> <div>38 of 39</div>               | <div>COUNTIES REPRESENTED</div> <div>15</div>                                       |

## WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Maryland families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MARYLAND FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

| EXPENSE CATEGORY                                          | RESPONSES | MEDIAN    | MEAN      | TOTAL REPORTED |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|----------------|
| Attorney Fees                                             | 27        | \$30,000  | \$91,630  | \$2,474,000    |
| Lost Wages                                                | 15        | \$10,000  | \$230,800 | \$3,462,000    |
| Other Court Fees                                          | 7         | \$4,000   | \$3,757   | \$26,300       |
| Therapy / Evaluations                                     | 7         | \$1,200   | \$4,029   | \$28,200       |
| Reunification Services                                    | 8         | \$0       | \$550     | \$4,400        |
| GAL Fees                                                  | 9         | \$0       | \$6,500   | \$58,500       |
| Asset Loss                                                | 10        | \$55,000  | \$681,000 | \$6,809,999    |
| Median Family Burden (9 families reporting 3+ categories) | —         | \$362,000 | —         | —              |

**Median vs. mean:** Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

|                           |                        |     |          |
|---------------------------|------------------------|-----|----------|
| Median months lost        | <div><div></div></div> | 18  | 1.5 yrs  |
| Mean months lost          | <div><div></div></div> | 26  | 2.2 yrs  |
| Total across all families | <div><div></div></div> | 655 | 54.6 yrs |

## 03 WHO IS REPORTING · MARYLAND

Most families documenting in Maryland are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

## CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

## CASE STATUS

|                                    |  |    |     |
|------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Active case: stuck or delayed      |  | 16 | 41% |
| Not provided                       |  | 12 | 31% |
| Case closed: more than 2 years ago |  | 5  | 13% |
| Case closed: within last 2 years   |  | 4  | 10% |
| Active case: progress being made   |  | 1  | 3%  |

## SYSTEM AFFECTED

|                                      |  |    |     |
|--------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Family Court Only                    |  | 19 | 49% |
| Both Family Court and CPS            |  | 12 | 31% |
| Unknown                              |  | 4  | 10% |
| CPS (Child Protective Services) Only |  | 3  | 8%  |
| Family Court                         |  | 1  | 3%  |

## DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

## TIME IN SYSTEM

|                   |  |    |     |
|-------------------|--|----|-----|
| 1 – 3 years       |  | 12 | 31% |
| 3 – 5 years       |  | 7  | 18% |
| 6 months – 1 year |  | 4  | 10% |
| 5 – 10 years      |  | 4  | 10% |
| Over 10 years     |  | 4  | 10% |

## CUSTODY STATUS

|                                   |  |    |     |
|-----------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Visitation Only                   |  | 13 | 33% |
| No Contact / Total Loss of Access |  | 11 | 28% |
| 50/50 Joint                       |  | 7  | 18% |
| Full Custody                      |  | 3  | 8%  |
| Partial / Shared                  |  | 2  | 5%  |

## GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

## TOP COUNTIES

|                 |  |   |     |
|-----------------|--|---|-----|
| Baltimore       |  | 4 | 10% |
| Washington      |  | 3 | 8%  |
| Howard          |  | 2 | 5%  |
| Frederick       |  | 2 | 5%  |
| Allegheny       |  | 2 | 5%  |
| Prince George's |  | 2 | 5%  |

## TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

|                                                                             |  |    |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|----|-----|
| Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)         |  | 17 | 44% |
| Other: (Short answer)                                                       |  | 7  | 18% |
| High Conflict Divorce                                                       |  | 3  | 8%  |
| Other                                                                       |  | 2  | 5%  |
| False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report) |  | 2  | 5%  |

## 04 PARENT VOICES — MARYLAND

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Maryland comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



*The system has ripped away my rights and any stability I had provided my son over the last decade. It's SHAMEFUL!!!*

— RACHEL

## ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Judge denied motions to stop reunification efforts despite evidence of medical harm. GAL suppressing all evidence. GAL is lying and helping defendant, has not done a proper investigation, 100% one sided. Jumped on alienation narrative and ignores the defendant's felony [...]

— MARYLAND PARENT · ANONYMOUS

## MORE VOICES FROM MARYLAND

The system came in and ripped my daughter out of my arms with no due process and created years of severe, debilitating separation anxiety for her.

— NICOLE

CPS has filed to terminate my rights completely for my two older children. I was never informed of the 15-22 months “timeframe” they lied on every single court report and never acknowledged any progress I made

— HANNAH

CPS succeeded in traumatizing my children worse than any argument my kids father and I ever had. We have been living apart and in other relationships for a year now and I just got Unsupervised with my smallest child who was removed two days before Christmas after a YEAR of [...]

— TYLER

Granddaughter said father was abusing her. Rape kit and forensic nurses confirmed this. Judge ordered child back to abuser. Child was only 3.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has destroyed me and my children. They gave primary custody to an abuser, alcoholic and illicit drug maker and abuser. My children are nose diving in destruction. None of this is in their best interest.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ruined mine and my husband's life ruined my family. The CPS worker is a witch and ruins peoples lives.

— ALINA

## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*The system has completely destroyed my life. It has taken my child, my career and my freedom based off lies and false allegations with no evidence, in fact my accuser used the things they were doing to me as their defense and I was maliciously prosecuted instead of them because [...]*

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They are taking a dedicated full-time mother almost completely away from her children. And gave them to my ex-husband who was never present.

— JESSICA

Ex and wife never wanted the children. They just didn't want me to have the children. Covert-insidious form of abuse. Children aged out of the system. Ex hasn't contacted children in months/years. Adult children are still traumatized and in therapy.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Have destroyed my faith in the country live and fought and killed for. I lost my children, my life financial I'm struggling and I don't wish to happen to anyone.

— ABU

Broke mother and dimmed three childrens lights spirits and souls causing severe distrust and perpetual fear of abuser

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn us apart lost of stability

— SCOTT

Separated my two minor children. Placed my daughter in the arms of an abuser. Missed Drs. Appointments for chronically ill daughter and then stated they are just routine appointments when I told the court her dad was not taking her while in his custody

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This is been absolutely devastating for me but terroristically traumatizingfir my intentionally parented baby who's world has been turned upside down for profit. I am beyond mortified but determined to correct my mistakes and rescue my Baby Girl

— NIKKI

It's taken away our ability to advocate and protect our children. They're in danger everyday and we can't do anything to help them. No matter how we fight to protect them it's twisted as abuse towards the ex partner....never do they look at the abuse towards the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

## 04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*This system treated her word as fact and her lies as evidence. Treated me as a criminal*

— WILL

Left child in narcissists care, caused severe mental damage to child by completely alienating one parent

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Put my child in the hands of a sexual predator, completely dismissing his repeated disclosures and cries for help.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Broken my soul Made me sick I lost so much

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

To the mothers suffering from post partum dealing with the threat of having your infant taken is inhumane to all mothers but especially the ones in this delicate time contact me if need be I dont mind I would love to expose this corruption, my instagram is @blissfullyblunt I am [...]

— REBECCA

It has failed me. Not allowing me to be a father

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has allowed my children's father's mother to intervene on his behalf of ONE of our three children, his entire eight years of existence. While trusting my other two children to be with me full-time, they have allowed this woman to abuse, my son, myself and my entire [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Shattered it entirely

— SHERRI

The system has empowered my ex-wife with control, removed my son from my life, removed my daughter from my life. It was beaten me mentally as I just want to love my kids and give them the best things that I can but am no longer able to due to financial burden of using a lawyer [...]

— JOHN

**04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED**

*My family and their associates all assisted in attempted murder, and kidnapping of my child. There is trafficking and other crimes involved. Several counties and the FBI refused assistance when reported repeatedly for over a year. They stole my home my child and my finances.*

— KACIE

This system has shown me that it favors a mother no matter what. Despite overwhelming evidence to prove my ex-wife was lying and abusing the system to "win" the divorce I lost custody of my kids, I was kicked out of my house several times, I have lost about 20 months of time [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This parent coordinator routinely violates state law and constitutional law by requiring meetings with zero agenda and then engaging and attempting to enforce decisions about child's diet, friends, education, third parties, religion, medical care, and she attends child therapy.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

After having primary custody for over 8 years and being the primary caregiver for 14 years. the court decided to change custody in because of a military relocation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This was a well laid plan of attack! They hid evidence and dismissed anyone who told the truth and didn't conform to their plot against me. They would all sit in the courtroom with my ex discussing lunch plans and laughing while I stood in the hall frantically emailing law [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

31 Maryland parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 31 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.



**05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MARYLAND**

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Maryland families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

The system has ripped away my rights and any stability I had provided my son over the last decade. It's SHAMEFUL!!!

— RACHEL

Judge denied motions to stop reunification efforts despite evidence of medical harm. GAL suppressing all evidence. GAL is lying and helping defendant, has not done a proper investigation, 100% one sided. Jumped on alienation narrative and ignores the defendant's felony conviction for Aggravated animal cruelty, 2nd degree assault against mother (me), and refuses to believe the children when they disclose abuse that was reported by their pediatrician with CPS and the police investigating and almost removed the children from mother. The whole system is rigged and they don't care about the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— HANNAH

CPS succeeded in traumatizing my children worse than any argument my kids father and I ever had. We have been living apart and in other relationships for a year now and I just got Unsupervised with my smallest child who was removed two days before Christmas after a YEAR of family preservation while breastfeeding. Refused to place my 3 kids with family instead of fosters for two weeks. If it wasn't for the twins foster parent we would still be so far behind.

— TYLER

Granddaughter said father was abusing her. Rape kit and forensic nurses confirmed this. Judge ordered child back to abuser. Child was only 3.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

**05** FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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The system has completely destroyed my life. It has taken my child, my career and my freedom based off lies and false allegations with no evidence, in fact my accuser used the things they were doing to me as their defense and I was maliciously prosecuted instead of them because of being a male in a corrupt law enforcement and court systems that sees men as guilty first without any evidence and that doesn't believe women can be abusers and refuses to prosecute even with evidence.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— KACIE

This system has shown me that it favors a mother no matter what. Despite overwhelming evidence to prove my ex-wife was lying and abusing the system to "win" the divorce I lost custody of my kids, I was kicked out of my house several times, I have lost about 20 months of time with my kids that I was heavily involved with for their entire lives as a stay-at-home dad for many years of their lives. I was crushed and due to my ex-wife's poor choices our kids suffered more than anybody ever did. I did everything to protect my kids but the "silver bullet" hit hard. I tried everything in my power to ensure they were kept out and to try and finalize the divorce amicably but my ex thought she could lie to the courts so I wouldn't get her retirement. Total between both parties spent was well over \$100k which could have gone towards the kids and many other things. I was jailed for 70 days for allegedly waving to my 3 year old daughter. I was facing 5 years for showing up to watch my 16 year old daughter play volleyball on her 16th birthday. I did not contact her and the school was not on the list of places not to go, but I was arrested and am now on probation for 3 years for simply going to my daughters volleyball game at a location that I was freely allowed to be at.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

31 full approved Maryland comments are included in this appendix.

## 06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

### WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Maryland report comes from Maryland respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Maryland — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

### WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 39 Maryland families reporting here are not the universe of Maryland families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

### METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through [standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey](https://standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey). Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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### ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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